WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital with Emerging & Frontier Markets

MOROCCO

Africa

Information current as of October 2026

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WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Rabat	Capital and seat of the Royal Cabinet, government and Bank Al-Maghrib; centre of policy-making on investment and the 2030 World Cup programme	Public-private partnerships, administration, services
Casablanca	Commercial capital and home of Casablanca Finance City, ranked first in Africa and 38th worldwide in the October 2026 Global Financial Centres Index; site of Africa's largest desalination plant under construction	Financial services, fintech, industry, water infrastructure
Tangier / Tanger Med	Mediterranean port complex that handled 11.1 million TEUs and 161 million tonnes in 2025, anchoring Renault's export plants and a dense industrial base	Logistics, automotive, export manufacturing
Kenitra (Rabat-Salé-Kénitra region)	Automotive and battery cluster: the Stellantis plant exported almost 127,000 vehicles via Tanger Med in 2025, and Gotion is developing a battery gigafactory project	Automotive, electric-vehicle batteries, components
Jorf Lasfar / El Jadida	OCP's principal phosphate-processing hub; phosphate and derivative exports reached MAD 99.7 billion in 2025, and CNGR and Al Mada are developing battery materials there	Fertilisers, battery materials, chemicals, energy
Nador West Med (Mediterranean east)	New MAD 51 billion deep-water port and industrial complex, including an LNG terminal, scheduled to begin operations in Q4 2026	Port logistics, energy, industry
Dakhla / southern provinces	Site of the MAD 13 billion Dakhla Atlantic port (62% complete in June 2026, due by end-2028), designed as an Atlantic gateway for Sahel countries; territory subject to the UN-led Western Sahara process	Renewables, green hydrogen, fisheries, logistics

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Moroccan Investment and Export Development Agency (AMDIE) as the national investment promotion body, working with 12 Regional Investment Centres (CRIs) that handle project facilitation in each region
- Investment Charter (Law 03-22): job-linked grants of 5–10% of investment, territorial premiums of 10–15% for less-developed provinces, sectoral support of up to 5%, and negotiated State agreements for strategic projects of MAD 2 billion or more
- Casablanca Finance City, Africa's top-ranked financial centre, offering a dedicated regulatory and tax framework for regional headquarters, banks, insurers and investment firms targeting West and Central Africa
- Mohammed VI Investment Fund (state-owned, MAD 15 billion initial capital), which co-invests through sectoral funds with private managers such as A.P. Moller Capital's MAD 2.24 billion logistics fund
- Bank Al-Maghrib manages the dirham against a euro–dollar basket and is moving gradually towards greater exchange-rate flexibility; the Office des Changes administers the rules on transfers of investment income and capital
- Sector-entry routes: partnerships with OCP for phosphates, joint ventures with ONHYM (25% state stake) for hydrocarbons, and 99-year leases for agricultural land; foreign ownership is capped at 49% in air and maritime transport and fisheries
- The government's green hydrogen offer, which has drawn more than 40 proposals and approved eight projects worth about $43 billion

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Morocco in October 2026 combines macroeconomic stability, investment-grade credit standing and a deep industrial export base. GDP grew close to 5% in 2025 and Bank Al-Maghrib projects 4.4% in 2026, with second-quarter growth of 4% supported by a 21.2% rebound in agriculture. Inflation averaged just 0.3% in the first eight months of 2026, allowing the central bank to hold its policy rate at 2.25%. FDI inflows rose 91% to $3.33 billion in 2025 (UNCTAD), lifting the FDI stock to $80.8 billion, while the National Investment Commission has approved 381 projects worth MAD 581 billion and around 245,000 jobs. S&P restored Morocco to investment grade (BBB-) in September 2025 and Moody's moved its outlook to positive in March 2026. A new coalition government under Fatima Ezzahra El Mansouri, Morocco's first woman Head of Government, was sworn in on 16 October 2026, with continuity in the key economic, industry and foreign affairs portfolios.

Morocco's main structural challenge is water. Seven consecutive years of drought weighed on agriculture and rural employment until heavy rainfall in winter 2025–26, which lifted dam reserves to 76% in May 2026 from 40% a year earlier. The state has responded with a long-term programme that reduces dependence on rainfall: desalination capacity of 345 million cubic metres a year is set to rise to 1.7 billion by 2030, supplying 60% of drinking water, led by the 300 million cubic metre Casablanca plant. This creates a substantial pipeline of opportunities in desalination, renewable power, water networks and efficient irrigation. Job creation for young people is the parallel priority: unemployment fell to 9.5% in Q2 2026 but stands at 27.2% for 15–24 year-olds, and the new government has made employment, education and health its central commitments.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Water stress and rainfall-dependent agriculture	Growth and rural incomes swing with rainfall; 2026's strong harvest followed seven drought years, and Bank Al-Maghrib expects farm output to ease in 2027	A large desalination and dam programme is reducing rainfall dependence; water, irrigation and renewable-powered desalination are priority investment areas
Youth unemployment and social expectations	Unemployment for 15–24 year-olds is 27.2%, and Gen-Z-led protests in 2025 pressed for better jobs, education and health services	The new government has made jobs its first priority; investors creating skilled employment can access Investment Charter job premiums and strong official support
Western Sahara legal status (compliance consideration)	UN Security Council Resolution 2797 (October 2025) backed negotiations based on Morocco's autonomy proposal, but the territory's final status remains under a UN process, and the EU Court of Justice annulled EU–Morocco trade and fisheries agreements in 2024 over their application	Take specialist legal advice on projects or sourcing in the southern provinces; the October 2025 EU–Morocco exchange of letters provides preferential access with region-of-origin labelling

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
	to the territory	
Administrative process and commercial justice	The US State Department notes bureaucratic delays and limited specialist commercial-court capacity; Morocco ranked 99th of 180 in the 2024 Corruption Perceptions Index	Use the CRIs and AMDIE for facilitation, State agreements for large projects, and Casablanca Finance City structures and international arbitration clauses
Sector ownership limits	Foreign ownership is capped at 49% in air and maritime transport and fisheries, agricultural land cannot be foreign-owned, and OCP holds the phosphate monopoly	Structure entry through joint ventures, long-term land leases and supply or processing partnerships with OCP and other state champions
External balance and currency movements	Bank Al-Maghrib expects the current account deficit to widen to 4.6% of GDP in 2026 as investment imports rise, and the dirham is gradually becoming more flexible	Official reserves of about MAD 516 billion (around five and a half months of imports) and an IMF Flexible Credit Line provide strong buffers; hedge significant dirham exposure
Public investment and debt	Public debt is about 67% of GDP as the state funds ports, rail, water and a $20 billion World Cup 2030 programme	The budget deficit has fallen to 3.5% of GDP and the IMF projects debt declining to 60.5% by 2031; the programme creates a large pipeline for contractors and PPP investors

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Morocco's risk profile is among the strongest in Africa: it is the continent's only investment-grade sovereign with S&P, Moody's has a positive outlook, the IMF confirmed in March 2026 that it continues to qualify for the Flexible Credit Line, and inflation is near zero. Political continuity is well established under the monarchy, and the October 2026 transition to a new coalition government kept the key economic and foreign affairs ministers in place. The main sensitivities are structural rather than cyclical: water availability, which a large desalination programme is steadily addressing, and youth employment, which is the new government's central priority. Investors with activities, suppliers or sourcing linked to the southern provinces should treat Western Sahara as a specific legal and compliance matter, taking advice on EU rules of origin and labelling and on applicable international law. With sound buffers, a clear incentive framework and growing reform momentum, Morocco offers a predictable base for long-term investment.

MARKET ACCESS

Morocco is the only African country with a free trade agreement with the United States, has a free-trade area with the European Union, and is a member of the African Continental Free Trade Area, giving manufacturers based in Morocco preferential access to markets on three continents. Exports reached MAD 470 billion in 2025, led by automotive (MAD 159.2 billion, the top export sector for the third year running), phosphates and derivatives (MAD 99.7 billion) and agri-food (MAD 87.5 billion), with aerospace growing by almost 10%. Tanger Med is the country's main gateway, connecting Morocco to European and global shipping lines on the Strait of Gibraltar, and will be complemented by Nador West Med from late 2026 and Dakhla Atlantic by 2028, the latter designed to open an Atlantic route for landlocked Sahel economies. This combination of trade agreements and port capacity makes Morocco a natural platform for nearshoring to Europe and for expansion into West Africa.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Royal Cabinet (King Mohammed VI) and Head of Government Fatima Ezzahra El Mansouri	The King sets long-term strategic direction, including major infrastructure, the Atlantic initiative and the World Cup 2030 programme; the new government leads economic policy	Primary reference point for strategic, large-scale and State-agreement projects
AMDIE and the Regional Investment Centres	National investment and export promotion agency, working with 12 regional centres	Standard first point of contact for market entry, incentives and site selection

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
	that process and facilitate investment projects	
Ministry of Industry, Commerce, Investment and Economic Inclusion (Ryad Mezzour)	Leads industrial strategy and investment policy, including the automotive, aerospace and battery ecosystems	Key counterpart for manufacturing projects and Investment Charter support
Ministry of Economy, Finance and Public Performance (Fouzi Lekjaa)	Manages the budget, public debt and PPP framework, and oversees financing of the World Cup 2030 programme	Relevant for PPPs, tax matters and large public-investment programmes
Bank Al-Maghrib	Central bank; sets the policy rate (2.25%) and manages the dirham and official reserves	Relevant for currency, banking and financial-sector matters
OCP Group	State-owned phosphate group holding the national phosphate monopoly; phosphates and derivatives are Morocco's second-largest export sector	Essential partner for phosphate, fertiliser, chemicals and related energy investments
Casablanca Finance City Authority	Runs Africa's leading financial centre and its regulatory and tax regime for regional hubs	Preferred platform for financial-services firms and regional headquarters covering Africa

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The Confédération Générale des Entreprises du Maroc (CGEM) is the principal private-sector federation and the natural counterpart for domestic business liaison, alongside the American Chamber of Commerce in Morocco and European bilateral chambers of commerce. AMDIE and the Regional Investment Centres organise investor outreach and sector events, and Casablanca Finance City acts as a networking hub for financial services and Africa-focused investment. The Mohammed VI Investment Fund is an increasingly important co-investment partner through its sectoral funds. The World Bank Group, African Development Bank and EBRD maintain active programmes in Morocco covering infrastructure, water, energy transition and private-sector development, and the IMF's Flexible Credit Line underlines the country's standing with international institutions.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Morocco suits investors seeking a stable, investment-grade base close to Europe with access to African markets: automotive, aerospace and battery-supply-chain manufacturers using the Tanger Med and Kenitra clusters and Morocco's FTA network; infrastructure, water and renewable-energy investors taking part in desalination, green hydrogen, ports and World Cup 2030 projects; financial-services and fintech firms using Casablanca Finance City as a regional hub; and tourism, agri-food and logistics investors building on record visitor numbers and export growth. Investors considering activity in the southern provinces should factor in specialist legal advice as a standard part of due diligence.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage AMDIE and the relevant Regional Investment Centre
Open dialogue early to identify eligible Investment Charter premiums and, for projects of MAD 2 billion or more, the route to a negotiated State agreement.

STEP 2: Build relationships with the new government
Brief the incoming ministers for industry and investment, economy and finance, and energy on project plans, aligning with their focus on jobs and the World Cup 2030 programme.

STEP 3: Evaluate Casablanca Finance City for regional structuring
Consider CFC status for financial-services operations or an Africa regional headquarters to benefit from its dedicated regulatory and tax framework.

STEP 4: Position for water, energy and infrastructure pipelines
Track desalination, renewable-power, green hydrogen, port and rail tenders, and explore co-investment with the Mohammed VI Investment Fund or partnerships with OCP and other state companies.

STEP 5: Complete legal and currency due diligence
Confirm sector ownership rules and fund-transfer arrangements with local counsel and banks, and take specialist advice on any activity linked to the southern provinces.